Teaching Portfolio

Philosophy, Summary of Evaluations, and Sample Materials

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UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, IRVINE

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1 Summary

I started teaching economics courses in the summer of 2009 as a graduate student at the University of North Carolina, Chapel Hill (UNC). Since then, I have taught 30 economics courses at four universities: UNC, the University of Montana, the University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA), and the University of California, Irvine (UCI). I've taught students at all levels: principles, intermediate, and graduate. I have experience teaching classes with as few as 10 students to classes with up to 450 students. Student evaluations of my teaching are consistently excellent and continue to improve. My colleagues in the Economics Department at the University of Montana rated my teaching for the 2011-12 academic year as"outstanding".

In addition to classroom experience, I have been involved in a number of other activities that complement my teaching. I currently serve as the director of the Economics Learning Center: a new tutoring initiative for UCI students enrolled in principles and intermediate-level economics classes. At the University of Montana, I supervised 5 senior thesis research projects. As a graduate student at UNC, I completed the Teacher Training Program (TTP) provided by the Department of Economics.[1] Finally, teaching large lecture sections at UCI has given me valuable experience working with and delegating responsibilities to graduate teaching assistants.

[1] TTP is a year-long program developed by the UNC Department of Economics faculty and is designed to train graduate students to be effective teachers.

2 Philosophy

Proficiency in economic reasoning gives students important tools for analyzing and reacting to the events in their personal and professional lives. As voting citizens, students with backgrounds in economics are better-suited to be critical of policies proposed by elected officials and competing candidates. Economics training prepares students to be more conscientious participants in the political process, more analytical leaders, and more productive workers. Therefore, teaching economics is an important responsibility.

I teach economics because I want to have a meaningful and long-term impact on my students. My objective is to help my students develop strong economic reasoning skills. I am motivated by the prospect that, if I have done my job well, I will not only have taught my students *what* to think about economics, but *how* to think about economics. In doing so, I will have provided my students analytical skills that are more likely to remain with them for a long time.

Teaching well is challenging. Students are diverse in background, ability, and motivation. A simple teaching strategy is unlikely to produce uniform results across all students. With this in mind, I have developed – and continue to improve – a more comprehensive approach to teaching that respects the inherent differences among the students in my classes. My teaching strategy is based upon (1) organization and structure, (2) emphasis of recurring themes, and (3) variety of presentation.

Students benefit from organization and structure. A well-organized course makes learning easier because the learning objectives are made clear and students can appreciate how new ideas fit within the larger structure of the course. With this in mind, at the beginning of the semester I provide my students with a detailed outline of the course (See Section 10.2, for example.). I also take time to set out specific objectives for the course in the form of statements like "By the end of the semester, you should understand..." or "At the end of this course, you will be able to..." I take time during the semester to evaluate our progress on meeting the course objectives.

I accomplish three things by occasionally taking class time to relate the current course material with the broader objectives of the course. First, I keep students focused on the ultimate objectives for the course and not the intermediate concepts. Second, by periodically stepping back from the details of the course material, students can appreciate that they are still learning even if the ultimate objectives of the course haven't yet been reached. And finally, by periodically taking time to place the course material in context, I can emphasize the broad economic themes in the course material and, when possible, link these themes with what students may already know from other economics classes.

Organization and structure help students by reducing uncertainty about how their grades are determined. Students in a well-structured class have a better idea how their effort should be allo-

cated because they understand what their teacher expects of them. Each semester, I make sure to specify what I expect of the students in the syllabus (See Section 10.1 for an example syllabus). And I use lectures and homework assignments as opportunities to provide examples that are typical of the questions students should expect on exams. If students understand what actions are required for them to do well then, other things equal, they are likely to put in more effort.

Variety in a course is essential. As I've noted, students have different learning styles, abilities, backgrounds, and motivations. Most have attention spans that struggle to endure a full lecture. I vary the teaching methods that I employ in the classroom to increase the probability that a given student will find my teaching helpful. Variety also helps to make the course more interesting and engaging. As long as I can keep my students' attention, then I can teach them.

In addition to traditional lecture methods, I employ several other teaching tools to create variety. The following is a list of some of the teaching tools that I have employed in and outside of the classroom.

1. **In-class, small-group assignments**: I periodically use class time to break the class into small groups. I then give each group a question to work on. At the end of the exercise, a member of each group shares the group response with the class. This approach gives individual students who are struggling with a concept a chance to learn from their group members or to receive help from me. By learning the answers to the other groups' questions, each student leaves class with a study guide. And finally, periodic in-class, small-group assignments add welcome variety into the classroom. See Section 10.3 for an example of a small-group exercise from my money and banking course.

2. **"Clicker" technology**: In the spring of 2013, I began experimenting with "clicker technology" in my large principles of macroeconomics section.[2] Large lecture sections are particularly challenging teaching environments. "Clicker technology" allows me to pose questions to the class and receive immediate responses. With this, students have an incentive to come to class, to be engaged, and to be ready to answer questions for grades. Also, I can use the feedback to evaluate in real-time whether the students are comprehending the material.

3. **Computational exercises**: Modern dynamic macroeconomic models are best appreciated using "hands-on" simulation methods and I have found that even undergraduates can successfully simulate simple dynamic models. In my intermediate macroeconomics course, I require that my students write Excel files to simulate the Solow growth model and a simple

[2]The specific application I use is called Top Hat Monocle (THM). THM does not require students to purchase or rent additional hardware: they can use a cellular phone with SMS capability or any device with Wi-Fi, provided the classroom has Wi-Fi. Additionally, THM accommodates several question types including multiple choice, matching, sorting, free response, among others. See: https://www.tophatmonocle.com/ for more information.

business cycle model with backward-looking inflation expectations. My graduate macroeconomic theory students use a combination of Excel, Matlab, and Dynare to produce simulations of dynamic macroeconomic models.

4. **In-class discussions of assigned readings**: On occasion, I use class time to discuss assigned readings with the class. Students benefit from verbally exchanging their ideas with others and this can be especially true after they have read a challenging economic text. But students also benefit from structure. I adopt the definition of classroom discussion used by Salemi and Hansen (2005): "a highly structured and carefully planned activity in which students investigate the meaning of a reading."[3]. To maintain control of the educational process, I provide the students with the discussion questions in advance. See Section 10.4 for sample discussion questions that I prepared for my graduate macroeconomic theory course.

5. **Current event blog assignment**: In the spring of 2012, I had the students in my money and banking class contribute to a blog about current events related to our course. The primary purpose was to encourage my students to link course concepts with current news developments. The secondary purpose was to give the students an incentive to write better since their work was being made public. The blog is available here: See Section 9.1 for a detailed description of the assignment.

I plan to continue to develop the above list by developing additional assignments and exercises that will allow to teach more effectively.

While teaching well is a challenge, it is also an opportunity. Every interaction with a student is an opportunity to teach. Every exam question that I grade and every question that I answer by email is a chance for me to clarify a particular point, correct a misunderstanding, or to simply provide encouragement to keep up good work. As a teacher, I have an obligation to provide organized and structured courses. But I also feel a responsibility to look for teaching opportunities and to take advantage of them. In doing so, I hope that my work will leave a long-term impression on my students.

[3] Salemi, Michael K. and W. Lee Hansen. 2005. *Discussing Economics*. Northampton, MA: Edward Elgar, p. 2

3 Summary of Teaching Evaluations

3.1 The University of California, Irvine

I have taught eight complete courses at UCI and I have received great student evaluations for each of them. Table 4 provides a summary of my teaching evaluations for the courses I taught at UCI between the fall of 2013 and the spring of 2014. The statistics do not cover the Money and Banking course that I taught over the summer of 2014 because the evaluation used by the UCI Summer Session is not the same as the evaluation used during the regular quarter.

In general, my evaluation scores at UCI have been high and consistent across all classes and quarters. The three areas where I received the highest scores were in my ability to express my knowledge, my enthusiasm for the course material, and my willingness to meet with students outside of class. I am especially proud to have done well in these areas because these are aspects of my teaching style that I have worked to cultivate. I make a point of being accessible to my students. And I hope that my enthusiasm will increase my students' motivation to learn.

Compared to the other items in Table 4, fewer students responded favorably to statement "The emphasis on understanding rather than memorization was:". This highlights a challenge that I am learning how to manage. But on the one hand, I want students to develop a deep understanding of the material that is based more on intuition rather than memorized fact. On the other, I know that to develop intuition, we have to have learned facts that form the reference points for our intuition. Furthermore, I like to reduce uncertainty in my classes by making it clear in advance which types of questions will be on examinations and how the questions will be phrased. To some students it may seem like I ask them to *memorize* a lot of things, but I'm confident that I'm requiring them to *learn* whether they always appreciate that or not.

3.2 The University of California, Los Angeles

I taught 3 classes at UCLA. I taught Intermediate Macroeconomics (Econ 102) twice: once in the fall of 2013 and then again in the fall of 2014. More recently, I taught Principles of Economics (Econ 1) this past summer. Table 2 summarizes my evaluations for all courses taught at UCLA.[4] Overall, I received good evaluations while at UCLA and my evaluations improved with each course as I adjusted to teaching UCLA students. On average, my strongest areas appear to be in class organization and my communication skills. But by the summer 2014 course, I received strong evaluations in all categories.

Table 5 reflects how my evaluations at UCLA compared with the evaluations of other faculty

[4] Like most institutions, the student evaluation form at UCLA is a set of multiple choice questions and each student chooses numbers between 1 ("Low") and 9 ("High") on the various questions.

in the Department of Economics. There is a clear trend of improvement. In the fall of 2013, I was ranked roughly in the middle of the colleagues in the department. By the summer of 2014, I was ranked highest out of all faculty. This is a reflection of my willingness to adapt how I teach in response to the needs of my students. As I learned more about UCLA students, I was also able to teach them better.

3.3 The University of Montana

I received consistently high evaluations from students while I was at UM. The student evaluation form at UM allows students to evaluate their instructors along five dimensions including overall effectiveness in the classroom. Table 4 in Section 6 summarizes my teaching evaluations for the 13 courses that I taught at UM from the fall of 2011 through the spring of 2013. The numbers in boldface on the right-hand side of the table reflect my average evaluations across all courses. On average, I am rated most highly for (1) being available to assist students and (2) for my overall effectiveness in the classroom. But in general, my evaluations are consistently high across the five dimensions of evaluation and across all courses.

My teaching evaluations have been improving while I have been UM. Table 5 summarizes my teaching evaluations for the Principles of Macroeconomics (ECNS 202) courses that I taught at UM. Each column reports the average evaluations for all of the sections I taught in that semester. While it's a small sample, my evaluations appear to be improving over time on almost all metrics. Note that the Summer 2012 course is an outlier because it had an enrollment of only 14 students. In contrast, all other Principles of Macroeconomics courses that I taught have had enrollment between 74 and 105.

Tables 6 and 7 summarize my teaching evaluations for the two Intermediate Macroeconomics (ECNS 302) courses and the two Money and Banking courses that I taught at UM. Again, the sample is small, but the numbers continue to suggest that I am consistently effective in the classroom and that my teaching quality is improving with time.

In addition to student evaluations, my teaching record at UM for the 2011-2012 academic year was reviewed by the Faculty Evaluation Committee (FEC) in the Economics Department. Based on evidence from observations of my teaching and the results from my students' evaluations, the committee rated my teaching performance as "outstanding." Additionally, the FEC noticed that I am "engaging, well-prepared, and well-liked by the students." A copy of the letter prepared by the FEC is provided in Section 8.

3.4 The University of North Carolina - Chapel Hill

As a graduate student at UNC, I taught 7 courses of Introduction to Economics (Econ 101) and 2 courses of Financial Markets and Economic Fluctuations (Econ 423). Summaries of my evaluations are contained in Section 7. In general, my evaluations were strong. In particular, Table 9 indicates that my student evaluations were consistently high and exceeded both the average evaluations of other instructors of the same course and the average evaluations of all instructors in the Department of Economics. Table 8 shows that the evaluations of my Financial Markets courses were less strong, but still generally comparable with the average evaluation of all teachers in the department.

4 Evaluations from the University of California, Irvine

Table 1: **Evaluations from all courses** taught at the University of California, Irvine from the fall of 2013 through the spring of 2014. Courses include: Basic Economics I and II, Intermediate Economics III, Intermediate Economics III: Quantitative, Financial Markets, Money and Banking.

	Fall 2013	**Winter 2014**	**Spring 2014**	**All Qtrs**
Class preparation and organization:	5.8	5.6	5.9	**5.8**
Instructor's ability to express his/her knowledge:	6.0	5.9	6.0	**6.0**
Emphasis on understanding rather than memorization:	5.7	5.5	5.7	**5.6**
Instructor's enthusiasm and interest in the course:	6.0	6.1	6.1	**6.1**
Instructor's willingness to meet with and help students:	5.9	6.1	6.1	**6.0**
Overall, I would rate this instructor as:	**5.5**	**5.5**	**5.6**	**5.5**
Overall, the value of this course was:	**5.7**	**5.5**	**5.7**	**5.6**

All evaluations are based on a scale from 1 to 7 points with a score of 1 indicating "Among the worst" and 7 indicating "Among the best."

5 Evaluations from the University of California, Los Angeles

Table 2: **Evaluations for all courses** taught at the University of California, Los Angeles from the fall of 2013 through the winter of 2014. Courses include: Intermediate Macroeconomics (Econ 102) and Principles of Microeconomics (Econ 1).

	Fall 2013	**Winter 2014**	**Summer 2014**	**All Courses**
The instructor was concerned about student learning.	7.7	8.1	8.0	**7.9**
Class presentations were well prepared and organized.	7.9	7.9	8.1	**8.0**
Students felt welcome in seeking help.	7.4	8.1	8.2	**7.9**
The instructor had good communication skills.	7.8	8.2	8.2	**8.1**
You have learned something you consider valuable.	7.5	7.9	8.2	**7.8**
Your overall rating of the instructor.	**7.8**	**8.2**	**8.3**	**8.1**

All evaluations are based on a scale from 1 to 9 points with a score of 1 indicating "Low" and 7 indicating "High." *Department average* and *Relative rank* are for all instructors of undergraduate courses in the Department of Economics at UCLA.

Table 3: **My course evaluations courses relative to other economics instructors** taught at the University of California, Los Angeles from the fall of 2013 through the winter of 2014. Courses include: Intermediate Macroeconomics (Econ 102) and Principles of Microeconomics (Econ 1).

	Fall 2013	**Winter 2014**	**Summer 2014**
Overall rating: Mean (out of 9)	7.8	8.2	8.3
Overall rating: Median (out of 9)	9.0	9.0	9.0
Department average	7.5	7.4	7.5
Relative rank	10 out of 22	4 out of 21	1 out of 21

All evaluations are based on a scale from 1 to 9 points with a score of 1 indicating "Low" and 7 indicating "High." *Department average* and *Relative rank* are for all instructors of undergraduate courses in the Department of Economics at UCLA.

6 Evaluations from the University of Montana

Table 4: **Evaluations from all courses** taught at the University of Montana from fall 2011 through spring 2013. Courses include: Principles of Macroeconomics (ECNS 202), Intermediate Macroeconomics (ECNS 302), and Money and Banking (ECNS 313).

	ECNS 202	**ECNS 302**	**ECNS 313**	**ECNS 513**	**All Courses**
Able to obtain useful assistance outside of class?	4.3	4.5	4.7	5.0	**4.4**
How clear and comprehensible was the instructor in presenting difficult material?	4.3	4.1	4.6	4.4	**4.3**
How well did exams reflect the content/emphasis of the course?	4.2	4.2	4.6	4.6	**4.3**
Quality of the text and teaching materials?	4.0	4.0	4.2	4.5	**4.1**
***Overall* rating of the teaching effectiveness of the instructor.**	4.3	4.2	4.7	4.8	**4.4**
Total	**4.2**	**4.2**	**4.6**	**4.7**	**4.3**

All evaluations are based on a scale from 1 to 5 points with a score of 1 indicating "Poor" and 5 indicating "Outstanding."

Table 5: **Evaluations of Principles of Macroeconomics (ECNS 202) courses** taught at the University of Montana.

	Fall 2011	**Spring 2012**	**Summer 2012**	**Fall 2012**	**Spring 2013**	**All Courses**
Able to obtain useful assistance outside of class?	3.8	4.2	4.8	4.4	4.5	**4.3**
How clear and comprehensible was the instructor in presenting difficult material?	3.6	4.3	4.9	4.5	4.5	**4.3**
How well did exams reflect the content/emphasis of the course?	3.8	4.2	4.9	4.0	4.6	**4.2**
Quality of the text and teaching materials?	3.6	3.9	4.4	4.0	4.4	**4.0**
***Overall* rating of the teaching effectiveness of the instructor.**	3.8	4.3	4.9	4.4	4.6	**4.3**
Total	**3.7**	**4.2**	**4.8**	**4.3**	**4.5**	**4.2**

All evaluations are based on a scale from 1 to 5 points with a score of 1 indicating "Poor" and 5 indicating "Outstanding."

Table 6: **Evaluations of Intermediate Macroeconomics (ECNS 302) courses** taught at the University of Montana.

	Fall 2011	**Fall 2012**	**All Courses**
Able to obtain useful assistance outside of class?	4.5	4.6	**4.5**
How clear and comprehensible was the instructor in presenting difficult material?	3.8	4.4	**4.1**
How well did exams reflect the content/emphasis of the course?	4.0	4.4	**4.2**
Quality of the text and teaching materials?	3.9	4.2	**4.0**
***Overall* rating of the teaching effectiveness of the instructor.**	4.0	4.5	**4.2**
Total	**4.0**	**4.4**	**4.2**

All evaluations are based on a scale from 1 to 5 points with a score of 1 indicating "Poor" and 5 indicating "Outstanding."

Table 7: **Evaluations of Money and Banking (ECNS 313) courses** taught at the University of Montana.

	Spring 2012	**Spring 2013**	**All Courses**
Able to obtain useful assistance outside of class?	4.7	4.6	**4.7**
How clear and comprehensible was the instructor in presenting difficult material?	4.5	4.6	**4.6**
How well did exams reflect the content/emphasis of the course?	4.5	4.7	**4.6**
Quality of the text and teaching materials?	4.2	4.2	**4.2**
***Overall* rating of the teaching effectiveness of the instructor.**	4.7	4.7	**4.7**
Total	**4.5**	**4.6**	**4.6**

All evaluations are based on a scale from 1 to 5 points with a score of 1 indicating "Poor" and 5 indicating "Outstanding."

7 Evaluations from the University of North Carolina

Table 8: Student evaluations of Financial Markets and Economic Fluctuations (Econ 423) courses taught at the University of North Carolina.

Question	**Spring 2009**			**Spring 2010**		
	My section	All 423 sections	Econ Dept.	My section	All 423 sections	Econ Dept.
Overall, considering its content, design, and structure, this course was excellent.	**3.7**	3.9	3.7	**3.4**	3.9	3.6
Overall, considering the constraints and opportunities inherent in the subject matter, this instructor was an effective teacher.	**4.0**	4.1	4.0	**3.6**	4.0	3.9
Overall, I learned a great deal from this course.	**4.1**	4.2	4.0	**3.7**	4.1	3.9
This instructor was one of the best I have had at UNC, fully deserving of a teaching award.	7 “yes” out of 18			3 “yes” out of 20		
Mean scores on a scale from 1 to 5 where 5=Strongly Agree, 4=Agree, 3=Neither Agree nor Disagree, 2=Disagree, 1=Strongly Disagree						

Table 9: Student evaluations of Introduction to Economics (Econ 101) courses taught at the University of North Carolina.

Question	**Fall 2008**			**Fall 2009**			**Fall 2010**		
	My section	All 101 sections	Econ Dept.	My section	All 101 sections	Econ Dept.	My section	All 101 sections	Econ Dept
Overall, considering its content, design, and structure, this course was excellent.	**4.3**	3.4	3.6	**4.2**	3.5	3.5	**4.3**	N/A	N/A
Overall, considering the constraints and opportunities inherent in the subject matter, this instructor was an effective teacher.	**4.4**	3.6	3.8	**4.5**	3.7	3.8	**4.4**	N/A	N/A
Overall, I learned a great deal from this course.	**4.3**	3.8	3.9	**4.4**	3.8	3.8	**4.3**	N/A	N/A
Mean scores on a scale from 1 to 5 where 5=Strongly Agree, 4=Agree, 3=Neither Agree nor Disagree, 2=Disagree, 1=Strongly Disagree									

Note that department-wide evaluation statistics were not available for Fall 2010.

8 Faculty Evaluation from the University of Montana

NON-TENURABLE FACULTY MEMBER EVALUATION FORM:

JENKINS	Brian	
LAST NAME	FIRST NAME	MIDDLE INITIAL
Visiting Assistant Professor		
PRESENT ACADEMIC RANK		
Department of Economics	College of Arts & Sciences	
ACADEMIC UNIT	COLLEGE/SCHOOL	

PERFORMANCE AT THE UNIVERSITY OF MONTANA IS:

SATISFACTORY ☒
UNSATISFACTORY ☐

RECOMMENDATION:

MERIT AWARD* ☐
PROMOTION* ☐
CONTINUE AT CURRENT RANK ☒
NON-RETENTION ☐

**** Merit awards or promotions to be funded by grants or school/college sources.***

COMMENTS:

The Faculty Evaluation Committee (FEC) is using the Economics Department's 2009 unit standards to evaluate the record of Brian Jenkins and his request for a normal salary increment.

Summary:
Dr. Jenkins is a Visiting Assistant Professor and is being evaluated on his teaching alone. Using the language of the 2009 unit standards, the FEC rated Dr. Jenkins's teaching 'outstanding' and voted unanimously for a normal salary increment.

Teaching:
The 2009 unit standards require, as a starting point, the achievement of an overall teaching effectiveness (OTE) score of 4.0 to be evaluated as 'outstanding'. Dr. Jenkins's scores averaged 4.21 (unweighted) or 4.19 (student-weighted), either of which would place him in the 'outstanding' category. Observations of his teaching found him to be engaging, well-prepared and well-liked by the students.

In addition to his classroom teaching, Dr. Jenkins advised two senior thesis students.

(append additional pages, as needed)

Signed by:

12/5/12
Faculty Evaluation Committee Chairperson — Date

Department Chairperson — Date

Dean — Date

I have read the recommendation(s) and/or evaluation(s)of the Faculty Evaluation Committee, the Department Chairperson, and attest to the accuracy of any documents submitted as evidence of performance.

12/6/2012
Faculty Member — Date

PLEASE SUBMIT, ALONG WITH SUPPORTING DOCUMENTS, IF APPLICABLE, TO FEC BY OCTOBER 15, TO DEPARTMENT CHAIRPERSON BY NOVEMBER 15, AND TO THE DEAN BY DECEMBER 15.

COPIES TO:
DEAN (1) ☐
DEPARTMENT CHAIRPERSON ☐
FACULTY MEMBER ☐
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(Ivory) 9/26/2012

9 Examples of Assignments Created

I have an interest in incorporating novel teaching methods into my courses. While I have been at UM, I have developed and implemented a couple of exercises that are designed to teach students through practical examples and to promote collaboration. One exercise is a "Current Event Blog." The activity requires that students collaborate on a semester-long blogging project by contributing written analysis of news related to course topics. A second exercise is an in-class group exercise designed to help students distinguish between idiosyncratic and systematic risk. In the following two sections, I describe these exercises in greater depth.

9.1 Current Event Blog

Brief Description: Students will collaborate on a semester-long project by contributing to a blog of current events related to money and banking. Each student will be evaluated based on the quality of his/her posts and on the quality of his/her contributions to the discussion.

Objective: The primary goal is to give students a meaningful opportunity to link the ideas that are learning in class to the currently unfolding events in the real economy. By having students contribute to a public blog, each student's writing and analysis will be visible to their peers. The public component of the assignment creates an incentive fir students to write more thoughtfully and carefully and to choose more interesting articles to review.

Motivation: This exercise is intended to improve upon the more traditional "current event" or "article review" assignment. In a traditional "current event" assignment, each student selects and reads a recent news article and submits a brief summary and critique of the article that is to be reviewed solely by the course instructor. Presumably, this type of assignment encourages students to apply concepts learned in-class toward analyzing current events and to perhaps criticize the conduct of public policy.

For a variety of reasons, current event-type assignments have a tendency to produce a misuse of both instructor and student time. Many students will not take time to produce a serious critical review of the article they have chosen. Others will not take the time to write well. The instructor is left reading poorly written papers; suspecting that the welfare students and instructor alike might have been greater had the assignment not been made in the first place.

Example: This exercise was implemented in my Money and Banking course at the University of Montana in the spring of 2012. The result of the students' effort is available here:

http://moniesandbanking.wordpress.com/

9.2 Distinguishing Between Idiosyncratic and Systematic Risk Class Exercise

Objective: The objective of this assignment is to teach students the difference between *idiosyncratic* or *diversifiable risk* and *systematic* or *undiversifiable* risk. By the end of the exercise, students should be able to:

1. Describe the difference between idiosyncratic risk and systematic risk.
2. Explain why idiosyncratic risk is diversifiable.
3. Explain why systematic risk cannot be diversified.
4. Explain how correlation with the business cycle might affect the price of an asset.

Motivation: Understanding the difference between idiosyncratic and systematic risk is more challenging for students who do not have the background in mathematics necessary to decompose the variance of a random variable into different components. Therefore, this assignment is designed to teach the difference by example.

Brief Description: The students will use coin tosses to generate random data that they are to interpret as asset returns. The data will be analyzed and used to obtain conclusions about the nature of idiosyncratic and systematic risk. The exercise is intended to take about 60 minutes divided over two class meetings.

In the last 30 minutes of the first class, students are divided into about eight equal groups. Each group tosses a pair of coins 20 times and records the outcomes of the tosses on a prepared handout. At the same time (or before class), the instructor will toss two coins and results will be revealed to the students. The students will have written instructions for mapping the outcomes from their coin tosses into "returns" for their respective groups. Explain to the class, that each group will have a different return-generating formula. At the end of class, each group will submit a record of their coin toss outcomes and implied returns to the instructor.

Between classes, the instructor will consolidate the results from each group. The instructor will use the generate plots of the returns from each group and of the average return over time. This will enable the students to see the systematic – i.e.: “average” – return compared against the individual group returns.

At the beginning of the next class, the instructor will reveal summaries of the returns from each group. The students will receive a handout with questions for discussion designed to help guide them through the analysis portion of the exercise.

10 Sample Teaching Materials

10.1 Syllabus

ECNS 202S: Principles of Macroeconomics

Section 01 / CRN: 30028

Spring 2013

University of Montana

Professor: Brian C. Jenkins
Office: 411 Liberal Arts
Office Hours: 3:30–5:00 PM on Tues. and Thurs.; Wed. by appointment
Email: brian.jenkins@mso.umt.edu

Course Websites:

1. Top Hat Monocle: https://www.tophatmonocle.com/e/762720
2. Moodle: http://umonline.umt.edu/

I will use Moodle to maintain records of your exam and handwritten homework grades. See below for a description of Top Hat Monocle.

Course Description: This course is an introduction to the principles of macroeconomic analysis. We will:

1. use economic principles to examine the causes and consequences of macroeconomic phenomena such as economic growth and fluctuations, inflation, and unemployment;
2. use simple models to study the determinants of a nation's income, level of prices, and interest rates;
3. study how fiscal and monetary policies influence the macroeconomy.

Textbook: Mankiw, N. Gregory (2009). *Principles of Macroeconomics*, Sixth Edition. South-Western.

Top Hat Monocle: Top Hat Monocle (THM) is an internet-based learning tool that I will use to manage in-class assignments, out-of class homework, and to distribute supplemental course materials. You *must*:

1. have a paid subscription to the THM site and
2. have daily access to a device with either:
   (a) wireless internet access (e.g. a laptop or and iPad with Wi-Fi) or
   (b) a cell phone with texting capability.

Please see the documentation on the THM *Student Quick Start Guide* handout (also available on Moodle) for instructions on accessing and using THM.
Save the following phone number in your cell phone: $\boxed{(\mathbf{315})\ \mathbf{636-0905}}$. This is the unique phone number for our course that you will use to submit responses for in-class questions by text message.

Teaching Assistant: The teaching assistant (TA) for the class is Cody Pedro. His email address is cody.pedro@umconnect.umt.edu. His office is 409 Liberal Arts and he is available in his office from 4:10 – 5:10 PM on Mondays and 3:10 – 4:10 PM on Wednesdays. Please contact Cody by email with any questions you have about the course material and feel free to visit him during his office hours for assistance.

Prerequisites: ECNS 201S: Principles of Microeconomics.

Attendance: You are not required to attend class. However, you should expect almost daily graded in-class exercises these will not be available for make-up. Furthermore, the textbook is a supplement, not a substitute, for in-class lectures and you will be held responsible for all topics covered in lectures. You may not expect to use my or the TA's office hours as a substitute for class time.

Academic Misconduct: I take it seriously and you should too. Confused? Try reviewing the Student Conduct Code:http://life.umt.edu/vpsa/student_conduct.php.

Students with Disabilities: If you require special accommodation, then you must submit documentation to me from Disability Services for Students to within the first two weeks if the semester *and* you must inform me in writing *at least one week in advance* of each instance for which an accommodation will be required.

Exams and Grading: Your grade will be a weighted average of your THM, handwritten homework and exam grades. The weights are:

In-class THM Assignments:	15%
Homework assignments:	10%
Exam 1:	15%
Exam 2:	15%
Exam 3:	15%
Final Exam:	30%

In-class THM Assignments: Expect graded THM assignments to be given almost daily. Missed THM assignments but I will drop your lowest three THM grades.

Homework Assignments: Expect two types of homework assignments each week:

1. short handwritten assignments
2. THM assignments to be completed out of class

Handwritten assignments will be handed in for a grade. The out-of-class THM assignments must be completed by the announced deadline. Late assignments will not be accepted, but the two lowest homework grades will be dropped.

Midterm Exams: **Thursday, February 21**; **Thursday, March 21**; and **Thursday, April 18**. No make-up exams will be given without an officially recognized university excuse. If you miss one exam, its weight will automatically be shifted on to the final exam (see below). If you miss more than one exam, I reserve the right to give you a zero for that exam.

Final Exam: **Thursday, May 16, 8:00–10:00 AM** The final exam will be comprehensive and everyone must take it. *If it will help your final course grade*, I will replace your lowest exam grade with your final exam grade. The final exam will be administered in the same room in which we meet for regular lectures. For more information about final exam scheduling see:
http://umt.edu/registrar/students/finalsweek2/Spring.aspx.

Grading Scale: I use the following scale to convert percentage points to letter grades:

A:	85% or above
B:	greater than or equal to 70% and below 85%
C:	greater than or equal to 55% and below 70%
D:	greater than or equal to 45% and below 55%
F	below 45%

Personal Responsibility: It is your responsibility to ensure that you are getting the assistance that you need over the duration of the course. I am available to talk with you after class, by email, and during my office hours. Your TA is available to help you by email and during his or her office hours. But ultimately you must take responsibility for your academic performance. *By remaining enrolled in this course you agree to the terms of this document.*

10.2 Semester Schedule Handout

ECNS 202: Principles of Macroeconomics
Spring 2013: Jenkins

Schedule

Class #	Date:	Chs. covered	Topic(s)
1*	1/29	2, 4	Introduction to Economic Theories and Models; Supply, Demand, and Competitive Markets
2*	1/31	4	Continuation of Supply, Demand, and Competitive Markets
3*	2/5	10	Measuring a Nation's Income
4*	2/7	10	Continuation of Measuring a Nation's Income
5*	2/12	10, 11	Continuation of Measuring a Nation's Income; Consumer Price Index (CPI)
6*	2/14	12	Introduction to US Economic Data; Production and Growth
7*	2/19	12	Continuation of Production and Growth
8	2/21	–	**Exam 1**
9*	2/26	13	Saving, Investment, and the Financial System
10*	2/28	13	Continuation of Saving, Investment, and the Financial System
11*	3/5	13	Continuation of Saving, Investment, and the Financial System
12*	3/7	16	The Monetary System
13*	3/12	16	Continuation of The Monetary System
14*	3/14	16	Continuation of The Monetary System

A class number marked with "*" indicates that the topics listed for that day are *projections* of what will be covered.

Class #	Date:	Chs. covered	Topic(s)
15*	3/19	16	Continuation of the Monetary System
16	3/21	–	**Exam 2**
17*	3/26	17	Money Growth and Inflation
18*	3/28	17	Continuation of Money Growth and Inflation
–	4/2	–	*Spring Break*
–	4/4	–	*Spring Break*
19*	4/9	17	Continuation of Money Growth and Inflation
20*	4/11	18	Open-economy Macroeconomics: Basic Concepts
21*	4/16	19	A Macroeconomic Theory of the Open Economy
22	4/18	–	**Exam 3**
23*	4/23	19	A Macroeconomic Theory of the Open Economy
24*	4/25	20	Aggregate Demand and Aggregate Supply
25*	4/30	20	Continuation of Aggregate Demand and Aggregate Supply
26*	5/2	20	Continuation of Aggregate Demand and Aggregate Supply
27*	5/7	21	Influence of Monetary and Fiscal Policy on Aggregate Demand
28*	5/9	21	Continuation of Influence of Monetary and Fiscal Policy on Aggregate Demand

A class number marked with "*" indicates that the topics listed for that day are *projections* of what will be covered.

10.3 In-class Small-Group Exercise

ECNS 313: Money and Banking
Spring 2013: Jenkins

Present Value / Yield Exercises

1. Rank the following payment streams from highest yield to maturity to lowest.

   (a) $i =$ ____ , rank = ____. A bank makes a 10 year fixed-payment loan of $20,000 with annual payments of $3,116.40 per year.

   (b) $i =$ ____ , rank = ____. A bank makes a 5 year fixed-payment loan of $20,000 with annual payments of $4,877.81 per year.

   (c) $i =$ ____ , rank = ____. You deposit $15,000 into paying interest that compounds annually. After 10 years, your deposit is worth $32,383.87

   (d) $i =$ ____ , rank = ____. A bank makes a 10 year fixed-payment loan of $15,000 with annual payments of $2,547.02 per year

2. Rank the following payment streams in order of decreasing present discounted value (or price).

   (a) $PV =$ ____ , rank = ____. A 20 year 5% coupon bond with face value $10,000 and yield to maturity $i = 0.09$.

   (b) $PV =$ ____ , rank = ____. A bank makes a 10 year fixed-payment loan at an interest rate of 5% with annual payments of $1,942.57 per year.

   (c) $PV =$ ____ , rank = ____. A bank makes a 5 year fixed-payment loan at an interest rate of 6% with annual payments of $1,186.98 per year.

   (d) $PV =$ ____ , rank = ____. A 10 year 5% coupon bond with face value $10,000 and yield to maturity $i = 0.03$.

10.4 Discussion Questions for Chapter 1 of *Introduction to Modern Economic Growth* by Acemoglu

ECNS 513: Macroeconomic Theory
Spring 2013: Jenkins

Discussion Questions

Read Chapter 1 (pp. 3–23) from "Introduction to Modern Economic Growth" by Daron Acemoglu available for free download from the Princeton University Press. Write short answers (simple sketches; not paragraphs) for the questions below and be prepared to discuss your answers with your colleagues in class.

1. Figures 1.1 and 1.2 are two different visualizations how of income per capita varied across countries in 1960, 1980, and 2000.

   (a) What is meant by "density of countries" on the vertical axes in Figure 1.1 and 1.2? What is the quantity being measured?

   (b) In Figure 1.2, log GDP per capita is measured on the horizontal axis. Why is log GDP per capita more useful than just GDP per capita for making cross-country income comparisons?

   (c) According to Figure 1.2, what has happened to the distribution of GDP per capita around the world since 1960? Can you identify any worrisome trends? Do you see anything to be optimistic about?

2. Income and welfare.

   (a) Why, according to Acemoglu, should we care about cross-country variations in income per person?

   (b) What does Acemoglu mean when he asserts that income per capita is not a "sufficient statistic" for the welfare for the average citizen?

(c) Acemoglu cites several examples of how economic growth might actually *reduce* the welfare of some members of society. What does this tell you about the risks of overly-relying on simple models – like the one we have been studying – to guide economic policy?

3. Origins of income differences

   (a) Figure 1.8 is striking. WHich two countries do you think had the slowest rate of growth in income per capita? Which ones had the fastest?

   (b) What does Figure 1.9 tell you about how challenging it is for a country to increase its standard of living?

4. Conditional convergence.

   (a) What does Acemoglu mean by "unconditional convergence"? How would Figure 1.13 be different if countries actually *did* converge unconditionally?

   (b) What does Acemoglu mean by "conditional convergence"? Why should we expect that countries will converge conditionally?

5. Correlates and causes.

   (a) What are the three country-specific characteristics that Acemoglu cites as being *correlated* with income per capita?

   (b) Acemoglu lists five potential *causes* of economic growth. Which does he conclude is the most important? Do you agree?